

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

QA Maturity Assessment

Score your quality capability across twelve areas against a behaviourally-anchored 1-5 scale — then decide the right level for your context, not the maximum.

Purpose

This assessment gives you a structured, repeatable way to describe how mature your quality capability is across the areas that actually move outcomes — from how testing is planned and how risk is used, through automation and CI/CD, to metrics, environments and skills. It replaces vague statements like "our testing needs to improve" with a defensible position: "we are at level 2 on test-data management and level 4 on exploratory testing, and here is the evidence."

Its second purpose is to force an honest conversation about the target. Higher is not automatically better. A level-5 capability in an area that carries little risk is wasted investment. The right maturity level for each area depends on the risk it controls and the delivery context you operate in.

When to use it

- In your first 60-90 days, to establish a baseline you can improve against.
- Annually or twice a year, to track whether your improvement programme is actually landing.
- Before asking for investment — a scored gap is far more persuasive than an opinion.
- After a merger, a reorganisation or a major incident, to re-baseline honestly.

Instructions

Score each of the twelve capability areas from 1 to 5 using the behavioural anchors below. Score what is genuinely true today across the whole organisation, not the best example you can find in your strongest squad, and not what you intend to build. Where behaviour varies between teams, score the typical case and note the spread. Then — separately — set a target level for each area based on the risk it controls. The gap between current and target, weighted by risk, is your improvement backlog.

Level	Behavioural anchor (what you would actually observe)
1 — Initial	Ad hoc and reactive. Depends on individual heroics. Not written down; not repeatable. Nobody could run it the same way twice.

Level	Behavioural anchor (what you would actually observe)
2 — Repeatable	A basic practice exists and is followed by some teams some of the time. Inconsistent between squads; largely undocumented or documented but ignored.
3 — Defined	A standard, documented practice is understood and followed across teams. Predictable, but still largely manual and reactive rather than optimised.
4 — Managed	The practice is measured and actively managed with data. Decisions are made on evidence; the practice is tuned based on what the metrics show.
5 — Optimising	Continuous improvement is built in. The practice is efficient, largely automated where sensible, and the organisation adapts it proactively as context changes.

THE TARGET IS NOT ALWAYS 5

Set each target from risk, not ambition. A capability that guards a payments flow sold against SLAs may warrant level 4-5; documentation of a low-traffic internal admin tool may be perfectly healthy at level 2. Chasing level 5 everywhere burns budget and credibility on work that does not reduce meaningful risk.

Worked example

Here is the assessment completed for Northstar Digital. Current scores reflect the inherited state; targets are set for the next 12 months, weighted by the risk each area controls given Northstar's goals (ship faster without more incidents; make the public API dependable enough to sell against SLAs; control cost).

Capability area	Current	Target	Evidence / rationale
Test strategy & planning	2	4	No shared strategy; each squad decides its own approach. High leverage — raise to 4.
Risk-based test prioritisation	2	4	Testing is broad and late rather than focused on risk. Central to shipping faster safely.
Requirements & testability	2	3	Some squads write clear acceptance criteria; others hand over a Figma link. Aim for a consistent baseline.
Test design techniques	3	3	Strong exploratory testers apply solid technique. Already adequate — hold, do not over-invest.
Exploratory testing	4	4	A genuine strength. Maintain it; do not automate it away.
Test automation	2	3	~1,800 UI tests, ~25% flaky, distrusted, QA-owned. Fix trust and ownership before scaling — target 3, not 5.
CI/CD integration	2	4	CI runs unit tests on PR; releases human-approved. Quality signals not gating. High leverage for safe speed.
Environments	2	4	Shared staging unstable and unreliable. Directly blocks dependable testing — raise to 4.
Test data management	1	3	No strategy; "someone else's data" in staging. Foundational; move off level 1 first.
Defect management	2	4	Jira exists but severity/priority loose; escaped defects untracked. Needed for a credible risk story.

Capability area	Current	Target	Evidence / rationale
Quality metrics & reporting	2	4	Reports activity (test cases, bugs found), not outcomes. Must shift to escaped defects and change failure rate.
Skills, roles & career framework	2	3	No progression ladder or skills matrix. Enough to retain and grow the team; 3 is sufficient.

Reading this, the biggest risk-weighted gaps are environments, test data, CI/CD integration, metrics and defect management — the foundations that make everything else trustworthy. Automation scores low but the correct target is 3, not 5: the problem is trust and ownership, and scaling a distrusted suite would make things worse.

Blank reusable version

Capability area	Current (1-5)	Target (1-5)	Evidence / rationale
Test strategy & planning			
Risk-based test prioritisation			
Requirements & testability			
Test design techniques			
Exploratory testing			
Test automation			
CI/CD integration			
Environments			
Test data management			
Defect management			
Quality metrics & reporting			
Skills, roles & career framework			

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Scoring aspiration instead of reality — marking level 4 because a practice exists on paper that nobody follows. Scoring your best team rather than the typical case. Treating the assessment as a report card where every area must reach 5. Doing it alone in a room — a maturity score you did not build with the team is a score they will dispute. And running it once and never again, so you never learn whether anything actually improved.

How to interpret the results

- A large gap in a high-risk area (e.g. environments or defect management here) is where investment pays back fastest. Sequence these first.

- A large gap in a low-risk area is often best left alone — closing it consumes budget without reducing meaningful risk. Say so explicitly; deliberately not improving something is a legitimate decision.
- A high current score that the team disputes usually means the practice is fragile and person-dependent, not truly mature. Re-score it honestly.
- A cluster of level-1 and level-2 foundations (environments, test data, CI) will cap everything built on top of them. Fix foundations before scaling automation or chasing sophisticated metrics.
- Small gaps everywhere with no clear priorities usually means you scored too gently. Re-run with the behavioural anchors held strictly.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Present maturity as current-versus-target-weighted-by-risk, never as a single average score. An average invites the wrong question ("why aren't we a 4 overall?"). A risk-weighted gap invites the right one: "which of these gaps actually threatens our goals, and what will it cost to close them?" That is the conversation that gets you funded.